



FOOD FOR THOUGHT

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Why eating clean isn't enough

Performance does not begin at warm-up. It begins in the **kitchen** — quietly, consistently, every single day.

After working with athletes for over 20 years — from junior competitors to elite professionals — I can confidently say this: performance does not break down in the gym first. It breaks down quietly at home, in the kitchen.

Over the last two decades, I have reviewed thousands of food logs, blood reports, body composition scans and recovery metrics. I have seen athletes train hard, eat clean, and still struggle with fatigue, injuries, hormonal issues or stubborn deficiencies. Early in my career, I thought the issue was compliance or genetics. Experience taught me otherwise.

Most athletes are not under-eating. They are under-absorbing. This column is not based on theory. It is the result of years of observing patterns that repeat themselves across sports, ages and performance levels.

The question I started asking differently

Around five years into my practice, I changed one question during consultations. Instead of only asking what athletes ate, I started asking how they cooked. The responses were casual. Boiled. Fried. Sautéed. Whatever is quick. Aluminium pots. Old non-stick pans.

That single question explained blood reports more than any supplement protocol ever did.

I have seen iron-deficient endurance athletes eating spinach daily. I have seen magnesium-deficient strength athletes consuming nuts and seeds regularly. The nutrients were present on paper. They never made it to the cell.

That was my wake-up call.

Cookware is not neutral

Over the years, I have learned that cookware behaves like an invisible ingredient. Aluminium and worn non-stick surfaces are not passive. They interact with food, heat and acidity. Multiple lab analyses have shown metal leaching from aluminium cookware under normal cooking conditions.

From a performance lens, this matters deeply. Heavy metals interfere with mitochondrial efficiency, nerve conduction and oxygen utilisation. These are the foundations of endurance, strength, coordination and reaction time.

When athletes ask me why recovery feels slower despite good sleep and nutrition, cookware is often part of the answer.

Where technology earned my trust

Over the years, I've seen countless products marketed as 'healthy innovation'. I'm not easily impressed.

Most of them don't survive real kitchens or real performance demands. For athletes in 2026, it's time to treat cookware as an investment, not an afterthought.

Here's a quick checklist every athlete should look for in cookware:

- High-grade, food-safe stainless steel
- Non-reactive and rust-resistant surfaces
- Durable construction that holds up to daily use
- Easy to clean, so hygiene never becomes a compromise
- No coatings that leach or interfere with nutrition
- Supports waterless, oil-free cooking
- Allows food to cook in its own moisture at controlled temperatures